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Common Problem Framework

Building Credibility & Achieving Position

Dominant Buying Motives

Their dominant buying motive is either **positive** (**Reward** - something they really want) or **negative**, (**Fear** - something they really don't want). The greatest 'leverage' is achieved if you can uncover both.

If engagement is high, the best (fastest) way to learn the prospects DBM is to ask questions. (If engagement is low use positioning stories based on the 'Common Problem' Framework)

Questions are generally recognised as **hard fact** or **soft fact**.
Hard facts are **defensible** (able to be proved / disproved) and are usually right / wrong in their orientation. Information such as an address or phone number are hard facts.

Soft facts are often **opinionated**, they allow for interpretation by each individual and are not necessarily black or white.

If we want to appeal at an emotional level, we need to increase the amount of soft fact questions that we ask as all too often, industry terminology and detail strips soft fact questions from our discussions.

We want to magnify the opportunity or problem in the mind of the client, an easy way to do this is **'situation analysis'.** By asking the client or board to explain the consequences of action or inaction in applying your service / product we learn which of the consequences appear most real to them and those which they believe are good reason to act.

Two reasons why people don't buy;

Not aware of the opportunity / problem
Not sufficiently disturbed or excited about it.

The Event, Cause, Effect *(Common Problem)* Framework (Reveal Order)

2. Cause

1. Event

3. Effect

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The Psychological Power of Common Problems (to help you position)

- One of the softest ways to allow you and the client to 'merge' is to discuss '**Common Problems'.** We effectively use the **3rd Person Perspective** to 'create distance' between us, the problem, the client, and the solution - until such time as the client is happy to proceed and 'pick up the line of thought'…

- This framework is particularly useful for dealing with passive aggressive or unresponsive / disengaged prospects. ***(You can personify this character as "Mr Prickly")*** as it reduces the feeling of the client '**Being Channeled**' into an outcome by successive (leading) questions; which affirms trust and confidence in you, the adviser. *(Remember - they have to 'buy you' before they'll buy your solutions.)*

- Common problems are the easiest way to find common ground without asking the prospect to expose an area of **Weakness**. (Allowing both parties to **Save Face**)You will find many will volunteer their agreement on certain issues allowing you to explore the issue further and gain greater detail from them as you sense them relax. (You slip past their 'filter'.)

- Common problems allow you to establish **Credibility** and **Empathy** on a topic as you have effectively '**Called** out the **Ghosts**' (preempted possible objections) at the same time as you '**Reveal**' information in an orderly, sequential fashion through the power of **Storytelling**.

- The best part? It's all done with the use of story so you increase the chance of creating **Personal Relevance**, emotional connection and intensity with the client by creating 'Theatre in Their Mind'.

The Common Problem Framework. (Reveal Order)

1. Use the **Event** as the means by which to capture their **Attention** and **Intrigue**.

   (It serves as your mental anchor, helping to keep you on track…)

2. Then Reveal the (5) **Cause/s** so you can illustrate your **Experience** and **Technical Expertise**.

   (Remember to deliver this in 3rd person to create dissociation -*"…They struggle with… Their issue is…"*)

3. Finally, explain the (3) **Effects** so you can make a connection to the **Emotional Elements** relating to the event and therein, your **Empathy.** (Achieving Congruence).

   (This is delivered 'in character'. It's in 1st person (to you) but you need to shift tone and cadence so your prospect is aware you're 'acting'. This builds 'theatre in their mind' which evokes a more memorable and emotional response. We want the prospect to 'feel us'. They need to think *"this person gets me"*.

A *(Common Problem)* Story Example.

2. Cause

What (Symptom)	Why (Driver)
Poor debtor recovery	Nil debtor protocols in writing No single person tasked (& trained) with recovery Over reliance on 'Big' clients who pay slowly
Admin missing billing windows	Field team vs admin team culture Old tech admin approach Lack of management oversight
Lack of sales/ low margin	Lack of 'A' client clarity Ineffective use of discounting Nil or confusing outbound message No strategy for blue ocean clients
Stock rotation / Supply issues	Inadequate financial controls around stock management Lack of diversity in stock price point/ decision lead times
Natural Volatility / Undercapitalised	Lack of modelling / forecasting Growing too fast - over trading Strained financier relations due to 'bad weather' friendship.

1. Event

Business owner dealing with short term cash flow issues.

3. Effect

What (Symptom)	How it's articulated
Owner fixated on surviving - not improving. (Positive Outlook)	"How do I pay wages this week - how do I tell my partner we're taking a paycut" "Why me?" "This isn't fair..." "I just need to get through this period - everything will work out." (Won't it?)
Slips into avoidance - buys into the 'whole economy' theory. (Intensity)	"I don't want to see the data; that's the last thing I feel like doing - I know I'm in trouble" "It's just a sign of the times; everyone is struggling, nothing we can do about it." (Lashes out at those around them)
Just keep digging mentality (Competency)	"We just need to keep doing what's worked in the past - but do more of it. If we just work longer & harder & hope for better times" (The same old thing, the same old way but magical outcomes expected)

Notes

1. We